15 Smart Questions to Ask

Your APEX Counselor

A practical guide for small businesses navigating government contracts, based on the FREE PTAC service.

Created by GovCon Giants

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Based on the FREE government service for small businesses | PTAC

1. Can You Help Evaluate My Business?

Start with the basics. Give your APEX counselor a clear picture of your business-who you are, what you do, your experience, and your goals. Then ask: "Based on this, do you think I'm ready to pursue prime government contracts, or would it be smarter to start as a subcontractor?" Their feedback will shape your path.

2. What Do I Need to Be Successful?

Ask them to assess your current readiness. Do you need certifications? More experience? Better capability statements? Maybe you need help identifying teaming partners. This question helps uncover blind spots and creates a roadmap for growth.

3. Can You Help with Market Research?

Instead of diving straight into bidding, ask: "Can you help me understand the market?" APEX can help you identify which agencies buy what you sell, how much they spend, and who your competitors are. This is key to finding hidden opportunities.

4. What Area Are You Most Experienced In?

Every counselor has different strengths. Some focus on federal contracts, others know state or local procurement better. Find out what their specialty is so you can tap into their strongest insights.

5. Do You Have Any Contacts in My Industry?

Networking is everything. Ask if they know anyone in your niche who works at a government agency or a prime contractor. They might be able to introduce you or guide you to the right people.

6. What Can I Do to Increase My Odds for Success?

Ask for actionable advice: "What do successful businesses like mine do differently?" Whether it's refining your pitch, building a stronger proposal, or attending specific events-get tailored tips for boosting your win rate.

7. Are There Local Projects with No Bidders?

There are often city or municipal projects that go unnoticed. Ask if they know of any bids with zero or very few responses. These are golden opportunities where you might be the only one applying.

8. What Meetings or Organizations Should I Join?

Ask which industry groups, chambers of commerce, or procurement events are worth your time. Showing up in the right spaces can help you build credibility and meet decision-makers.

9. Who is the Most Successful Client You Know?

Learn from the best. Ask: "Who's crushing it in this space, and what are they doing right?" If possible, ask for a warm intro so you can learn from someone further along in the game.

10. What Common Mistakes Do You See?

Avoid costly errors by learning from others. Ask about red flags and rookie mistakes-like missing deadlines, submitting incomplete proposals, or failing to follow up with contracting officers.

11. Can You Recommend Any Free or Low-Cost Training?

APEX often knows about free government-funded webinars, workshops, and online courses. Ask what resources are out there to build your knowledge without hurting your budget.

12. What Areas is the Government Investing In Right Now?

Ask your counselor about current trends and priorities in federal, state, or local spending. Whether it's cybersecurity, clean energy, infrastructure, or healthcare-knowing where the money is going helps you align your offerings with real demand.

13. What Should My Capability Statement Include?

Your capability statement is your government résumé. Ask for feedback or a template. A strong, focused statement can help you stand out when reaching out to agencies or teaming partners.

14. Can You Walk Me Through SAM.gov or Other Bid Portals?

Navigating SAM.gov and other procurement platforms can be overwhelming. Ask your counselor for a walkthrough or a tutorial so you don't miss critical opportunities or make costly mistakes.

15. Have You Heard of GovCon Giants?

If they haven't, introduce them! Let them know that GovCon Giants provides free and low-cost education, interviews, and resources specifically designed for small and minority-owned businesses

in government contracting. Suggest they reach out for training support on your behalf.